

Learning Python

- `Counter(iterable)` (from `collections`) builds a dictionary subclass that maps each element to its frequency. For example, `Counter([1,1,2,3,3,3])` gives `{3:3, 1:2, 2:1}`. It supports arithmetic operations and is the go-to tool for frequency counting in interview problems.
- `most_common(n)` returns a list of the n most frequent elements as `(element, count)` pairs, sorted in descending order. Omitting n returns all elements. In the `topKFrequent` solution, iterating over `map.n.most_common()` and collecting the first k keys gives exactly the top- k most frequent elements in $O(n \log n)$ time.